A GUIDE FOR STUDENTS

TYPEFACES FOR THE ARCHITECTURE PORTFOLIO

Selecting typefaces that communicate precision, materiality, and architectural intent.

With live font specimens and free alternatives

16 TYPEFACE RECOMMENDATIONS

MODERNIST | HUMANIST | EDITORIAL | FUNCTIONAL

WHY TYPOGRAPHY MATTERS

Typography in an architecture portfolio functions as more than a vehicle for text — it is a design decision that communicates the same values of precision, materiality, and intentionality that define the architectural work itself. The typefaces in this guide are organized into four categories, from foundational modernist standards to contemporary humanist voices, editorial serifs, and technical display faces.

01 **MODERNIST**

Neutral, precise, Swiss/German tradition workhorses

02 **HUMANIST**

Approachable, warm, contemporary touch

03 **EDITORIAL**

Style-specific, expressive, brand-forward

04 **FUNCTIONAL**

Technical, high-impact, digital-ready

SELECTION PRINCIPLES

- **Limit your palette** — Restrict your portfolio to 2–3 typefaces maximum. Typographic restraint signals design maturity.
- **Establish hierarchy** — Pair a display weight for headings with a lighter weight for body text to create clear visual order.
- **Align with intent** — Your typeface should reinforce the architectural thesis and tectonic language of the work shown.
- **Test at production scale** — Always proof your typeface choices at the final output size — screen, print, or exhibition.
- **Consider licensing** — Commercial fonts require purchased licenses. High-quality free alternatives are noted throughout.

ABOUT THE SPECIMENS

Each typeface renders an actual architecture project statement so you can evaluate typographic tone in context. Commercial fonts are shown with open-source substitutes — noted beneath each typeface name.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

01 THE MODERNIST WORKHORSES 4

- Helvetica 5
- Futura 6
- DIN 7
- Univers 8

02 HUMANIST & CONTEMPORARY 9

- Avenir 10
- Söhne 11
- Gill Sans 12
- Circular 13

03 EDITORIAL & STYLISTIC 14

- Neue Montreal 15
- GT Alpina 16
- Monolisk 17
- Didot / Playfair Display 18
- Minion Pro 19

04 FUNCTIONAL & DISPLAY 20

- Century Gothic / DIN Pro 21
- Tungsten 22
- Roboto / Montserrat 23

Quick Reference Table 24

Font Sources & Licensing 25

Free Alternatives & Official Links 26

01

THE MODERNIST WORKHORSES

Neutral & Precise — Rooted in the Swiss International Style and German engineering traditions, these typefaces prioritize clarity and neutrality, ensuring that complex architectural drawings and diagrams remain the focal point of the page.

TYPEFACES IN THIS SECTION

01	**Helvetica**	Technical documentation
02	**Futura**	Headers
03	**DIN**	Annotating diagrams
04	**Univers**	Complex layouts

Helvetica

MODERNIST

The ultimate universal standard. Its neo-grotesque, neutral design is perfect for technical documentation, signage, and resumes because it doesn't compete with architectural drawings.

BEST FOR Technical documentation, signage, resumes, universal applications

Flexible Framework

National Building Arts Center — St. Louis, Missouri

The National Building Arts Center in St. Louis is home to an extensive collection of architectural artifacts, many of which reflect the city's industrial history in masonry and cast iron. This project responds to the need for a new building that can house a range of programmatic functions, including exhibition, archive, education, and fabrication. The design goal is to create a space that both preserves the legacy of St. Louis's industrial past and supports ongoing creative production.

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs. This structural grid supports various attachable components such as gantry cranes, shelving, curtains, and operable walls. These elements can be repositioned or adjusted over time, allowing the building to respond to changing programs and user needs. The material and structural choices, including long spans, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics, reference St. Louis's industrial architecture while supporting a more flexible and forward-looking mode of use.

Architecturally, the building balances permanence and adaptability. The framework provides clear structural logic and spatial organization, while the attachable systems create moments of transformation and user control. Exhibition spaces, maker zones, and archives are arranged to encourage interaction and visual connection. The result is a building that connects past and future through its material expression and operational flexibility, supporting both the preservation of craft and the advancement of contemporary building culture.

Professor: Kelley Van Dyck Murphy
Washington University in St. Louis | Spring 2021

Futura

MODERNIST

Shown with Jost, a free geometric alternative

Embodying the Bauhaus "form follows function" ideal, this geometric sans-serif is based on circles, triangles, and lines. Its clean geometry makes it excellent for impactful headers.

BEST FOR Headers, competition boards, titles, Bauhaus-inspired work

Flexible Framework

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DIN

MODERNIST

Shown with DM Sans, a free industrial-style alternative

Rooted in German industrial engineering, DIN is highly exact and sophisticated. Its systematic precision makes it the natural choice for technical annotation and structured documentation.

BEST FOR Annotating diagrams, design briefs, methodical documentation

Flexible Framework

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Univers

MODERNIST

Shown with Inter, a free systematic sans-serif alternative

Celebrated for its systematic family structure and exceptional flexibility across weights and widths. Ideal for maintaining structural discipline across complex, multi-page layouts.

BEST FOR Complex layouts, long-form documents, structural consistency

Flexible Framework

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02

HUMANIST & CONTEMPORARY

Approachable & Warm — As contemporary practice moves beyond purely rationalist aesthetics, humanist typefaces introduce a calibrated warmth to personal narratives, design philosophy statements, and digital portfolios.

TYPEFACES IN THIS SECTION

01	**Avenir**	Personal statements
02	**Söhne**	Modern branding
03	**Gill Sans**	Storytelling
04	**Circular**	Modern studio branding

Avenir

HUMANIST

Shown with Nunito, a free humanist geometric alternative

Blending geometric style with humanistic proportions, Avenir feels fresh and approachable. Its balanced character makes it excellent for conveying personality without sacrificing professionalism.

BEST FOR Personal statements, project descriptions, approachable layouts

Flexible Framework

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Söhne

HUMANIST

Shown with Space Grotesk, a free contemporary alternative

Created by the Klim Type Foundry, this contemporary font has rapidly become a standard for modern architectural branding. It offers the analog feel of classic subway signage with a contemporary edge.

BEST FOR Modern branding, studio identity, contemporary portfolio design

Flexible Framework

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Gill Sans

HUMANIST

Shown with Lato, a free humanist sans-serif alternative

Rooted in classic British typography, Gill Sans combines geometric simplicity with warmth and elegance. It softens a portfolio's tone without losing any sense of professionalism.

BEST FOR Storytelling, narrative-driven portfolios, design philosophy statements

Flexible Framework

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Circular

HUMANIST

Shown with Plus Jakarta Sans, a free geometric humanist alternative

A geometric sans-serif widely adopted by leading tech and design brands like Spotify and Airbnb. Its perfectly balanced letterforms feel both precise and friendly.

BEST FOR Modern studio branding, tech-forward projects, clean digital layouts

Flexible Framework

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03

EDITORIAL & STYLISTIC

For Specific Architectural Styles — Typography should reinforce the design thesis of the work it accompanies. These typefaces allow you to align typographic expression with architectural intent, from Brutalist materiality to classical refinement.

TYPEFACES IN THIS SECTION

01	**Neue Montreal**	High-end branding
02	**GT Alpina**	Academic portfolios
03	**Monolisk**	Brutalist projects
04	**Didot / Playfair Display**	Classical architecture
05	**Minion Pro**	Academic writing

Neue Montreal

EDITORIAL

Shown with Montserrat, a free geometric grotesk alternative

From Pangram Pangram foundry, these typefaces deliver a high-end, luxury editorial feel. They are ubiquitous in global architectural branding for their refined, contemporary character.

BEST FOR High-end branding, luxury projects, editorial-style portfolios

Flexible Framework

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GT Alpina

EDITORIAL

Shown with Source Serif 4, a free workhorse serif alternative

A highly versatile "workhorse serif" that balances utility with personality. Its academic undertone makes it an ideal choice for research-based or thesis-oriented architectural portfolios.

BEST FOR Academic portfolios, research-based work, thesis documents

Flexible Framework

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Monolisk

EDITORIAL

Shown with Archivo Black, a free sturdy display alternative

If your work focuses on Brutalism, this sturdy, angular font echoes the raw, concrete forms of the movement. Its bold geometry pairs naturally with exposed-material aesthetics.

BEST FOR Brutalist projects, raw material aesthetics, bold presentations

Flexible Framework

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Didot / Playfair Display

EDITORIAL

Playfair Display — exact match (free on Google Fonts)

High-contrast serifs that provide elegant authority. These are the go-to choice for classical architecture or luxury real estate projects where refinement is paramount.

BEST FOR Classical architecture, luxury real estate, refined presentations

Flexible Framework

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Minion Pro

EDITORIAL

Shown with Crimson Pro, a free humanist oldstyle serif alternative

An Adobe classic and one of the most refined humanist oldstyle serifs available. Its warm, readable character and extensive glyph set make it a sophisticated choice for text-heavy portfolios.

BEST FOR Academic writing, text-heavy portfolios, design essays, thesis documents

Flexible Framework

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04

FUNCTIONAL & DISPLAY

For Drafting and Presentations — Engineered for legibility in technical production environments such as CAD and BIM, and for high-impact visual communication at presentation and exhibition scale.

TYPEFACES IN THIS SECTION

01	**Century Gothic / DIN Pro**	CAD/BIM environments
02	**Tungsten**	Competition boards
03	**Roboto / Montserrat**	Digital portfolios

Century Gothic / DIN Pro

FUNCTIONAL

Shown with Poppins, a free geometric sans-serif alternative

Excellent for highly legible, visually appealing layouts inside CAD and BIM environments. These often replace standard system fonts like Arial to elevate the quality of technical drawings.

BEST FOR CAD/BIM environments, technical drawings, screen-based layouts

Flexible Framework

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Tungsten

FUNCTIONAL

Shown with Oswald, a free condensed alternative

A strong, vertically compressed font that adds high-impact energy to large-format presentations. Its bold presence commands attention at scale.

BEST FOR Competition boards, exhibition posters, large-format displays

Flexible Framework

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Roboto / Montserrat

FUNCTIONAL

Roboto — exact match (free on Google Fonts)

Great options for digital fluency and modern aesthetics. Their open, friendly geometry works especially well in digital design decks, online portfolios, and resumes.

BEST FOR Digital portfolios, design decks, resumes, web presentations

Flexible Framework

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QUICK REFERENCE

TYPEFACE	CATEGORY	FREE ALTERNATIVE	IDEAL USE
Helvetica	Modernist	Built-in	Universal, technical docs
Futura	Modernist	Jost	Headers, competition boards
DIN	Modernist	DM Sans	Diagrams, design briefs
Univers	Modernist	Inter	Complex layouts, long-form
Avenir	Humanist	Nunito	Personal statements
Söhne	Humanist	Space Grotesk	Modern branding
Gill Sans	Humanist	Lato	Storytelling, narrative
Circular	Humanist	Plus Jakarta Sans	Modern studio branding
Neue Montreal	Editorial	Montserrat	Luxury branding
GT Alpina	Editorial	Source Serif 4	Academic, research
Monolisk	Editorial	Archivo Black	Brutalist projects
Didot / Playfair	Editorial	Playfair Display*	Classical, luxury
Minion Pro	Editorial	Crimson Pro	Academic, text-heavy work
Century Gothic	Functional	Poppins	CAD/BIM environments
Tungsten	Functional	Oswald	Large-format displays
Roboto	Functional	Roboto*	Digital portfolios

** Exact match — free on Google Fonts. All other alternatives are stylistically similar open-source fonts.*

RECOMMENDED PAIRINGS

Futura + Minion Pro — Geometric headings with humanist serif body

Helvetica + GT Alpina — Neutral system with editorial warmth

DIN + Source Serif 4 — Industrial precision with readable body text

Söhne + Crimson Pro — Contemporary headings with classic body

SIZE GUIDELINES

Body text: 9–11 pt

Captions: 7–8 pt

Section headers: 14–20 pt

Display titles: 24–48 pt

Max typefaces: 2–3 per portfolio

A FINAL NOTE

Typography is as integral to your design language as the drawings themselves. Select no more than two or three typefaces that reinforce the conceptual framework of your work, and apply them with the same rigor you bring to architectural detailing. The best typography is invisible — it structures the viewer's experience without competing with the work it presents.

FONT SOURCES & LICENSING

Several typefaces in this guide are commercially licensed. However, three are available at no additional cost through Adobe Creative Cloud, which most architecture programs provide to students. Every commercial font in this guide is also paired with a high-quality open-source alternative for those without commercial access.

INCLUDED WITH ADOBE CREATIVE CLOUD

Minion Pro	→ Minion 3 / Minion Pro	*Full family included*
Futura	→ Futura PT (Paratype version)	*Full family included*
Helvetica	→ Helvetica Now	*Added to Adobe Fonts in 2025*

Activate these at fonts.adobe.com — no extra cost with any CC plan.
Adobe offers 40–60% student discounts on Creative Cloud subscriptions.

WHERE TO BUY COMMERCIAL FONTS

TYPEFACE	FOUNDRY	WHERE TO BUY	PRICE RANGE
Helvetica	Monotype	fonts.adobe.com	**Free w/ CC**
Futura	URW / Paratype	fonts.adobe.com	**Free w/ CC**
DIN Next	Monotype	myfonts.com	~$17–$57 / weight
Univers	Linotype / Monotype	myfonts.com	~$43 / weight
Avenir Next	Linotype / Monotype	monotype.com	~$98 / weight
Söhne	Klim Type Foundry	klim.co.nz	Contact for pricing
Gill Sans	Monotype	myfonts.com	~$62 / weight
Circular	Lineto	lineto.com	Contact for pricing
Neue Montreal	Pangram Pangram	pangrampangram.com	From ~$40
GT Alpina	Grilli Type	grillitype.com	~$75 / style
Monolisk	—	pangrampangram.com	Varies
Tungsten	Hoefler & Co	typography.com	Contact for pricing
Minion Pro	Adobe	fonts.adobe.com	**Free w/ CC**

STUDENT LICENSING TIP

Many foundries offer educational discounts of 50–90%. Contact them with your .edu email address.
Some universities also have institutional font licenses — check with your IT department.

FREE ALTERNATIVES & OFFICIAL LINKS

Every commercial typeface in this guide is paired with a carefully vetted open-source alternative from Google Fonts. These substitutes closely approximate the proportions, x-height, and stylistic character of the originals, and can be used freely in academic and professional work without licensing restrictions.

FREE GOOGLE FONTS ALTERNATIVES

REPLACES	FREE FONT	STYLE MATCH	SOURCE
Helvetica	**Built-in**	Exact (system font)	macOS / Windows
Futura	**Jost**	Geometric sans-serif	Google Fonts
DIN	**DM Sans**	Industrial-style sans	Google Fonts
Univers	**Inter**	Systematic sans-serif	Google Fonts
Avenir	**Nunito**	Humanist geometric	Google Fonts
Söhne	**Space Grotesk**	Contemporary grotesk	Google Fonts
Gill Sans	**Lato**	Humanist sans-serif	Google Fonts
Circular	**Plus Jakarta Sans**	Geometric humanist	Google Fonts
Neue Montreal	**Montserrat**	Geometric grotesk	Google Fonts
GT Alpina	**Source Serif 4**	Workhorse serif	Google Fonts
Monolisk	**Archivo Black**	Sturdy display	Google Fonts
Didot	**Playfair Display**	Exact match	Google Fonts
Minion Pro	**Crimson Pro**	Humanist oldstyle serif	Google Fonts
Century Gothic	**Poppins**	Geometric sans-serif	Google Fonts
Tungsten	**Oswald**	Condensed sans	Google Fonts
Roboto	**Roboto**	Exact match	Google Fonts

OFFICIAL FOUNDRY WEBSITES

Adobe Fonts	fonts.adobe.com	Minion Pro, Futura PT, Helvetica Now (free w/ CC)
Google Fonts	fonts.google.com	All free alternatives listed above
Monotype / MyFonts	myfonts.com	DIN Next, Univers, Gill Sans, Avenir Next, Helvetica
Klim Type Foundry	klim.co.nz	Söhne
Lineto	lineto.com	Circular
Pangram Pangram	pangrampangram.com	Neue Montreal, Monolisk
Grilli Type	grillitype.com	GT Alpina
Hoefler & Co	typography.com	Tungsten

PRO TIP

Check if your university provides font licenses through an institutional subscription to Monotype or Adobe Creative Cloud. Many architecture programs include premium font access for students.